



IT WAS THE FOOTSOLDIERS WHO FELL PREY TO THE TERRORISTS' BULLETS IN THE MUMBAI ATTACKS

BHASKAR PAUL

with Additional Commissioner (Armed Police) Raja E. Pawar and Additional Commissioner (Protection and Security) Vinay M. Kargaonkar. Several senior officers were not even consulted. Captain Anurag Grover, formerly with the 21 PARA (Special Forces) and an eyewitness to the operations at the Trident, says: "There was lack of coordination between agencies that were placed inside and outside the hotel. The heads of the multiple agencies didn't even have their telephone numbers or radio frequencies."

The mayhem started from the police control room, which should have ideally been



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that suits the politicians as plum postings are decided not on the basis of merit but political connections, caste and religion. Many senior officers allege that the Mumbai Police chief's "leadership failure" and coterie politics has demotivated the already ineffective force. Says Nitin Gadkari, BJP general secretary, Maharashtra: "The ruling parties want to appoint their officers as district SPS to get their work done. The state DGP A.N. Roy works under the influence of Sharad Pawar, so he never worked with the chief minister."

It didn't help matters that while Mumbai was battling terrorists, the appointment of the DG was being contested in the Bombay High Court. Says Gopinath Munde of the BJP, "There are certain regulations for IPS officers' postings. The CAT order set aside Roy's appointment, but the state Government continues to retain him as DG." The division between the office of Mumbai police chief and the DG became apparent when the action shifted to Maharashtra Police headquarters, as Roy coordinated with the chief secretary and the Home Ministry for deployment of the National Security Guard, which effectively led to a division in the force.

It is the failure of leadership that is more disconcerting. As the crisis peaked after the first couple of hours, Gafoor camped outside the Trident-Oberoi in his Honda City, along

manned by the Joint Commissioner of Police (Administration) Bhagwant D. More, who was camping at Nariman House. More refused to comment when contacted. In the absence of any clear leadership, Joint Commissioner of Police (Crime) Rakesh Maria took charge of the control room. The biggest criticism that is being levelled against the police commissioner is that he sat with his coterie outside the Trident, waiting for the armed forces to arrive, refusing to engage with senior IPS officers.

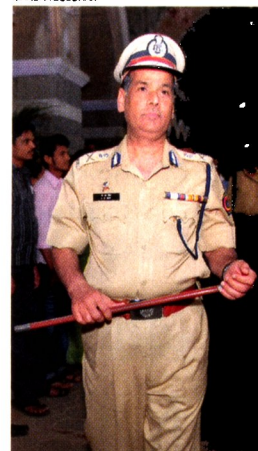
The willful behaviour of the commissioner peaked, say senior officers, when the FBI team arrived. At a meeting held at the DG's office, where senior Mumbai police officers, IB officials and members of the Home Ministry were present, it was decided that key evidence comprising the GPS data and copies of SAT phone intercepts would be shared with the FBI team. However, Gafoor refused to do so when the team landed at his office. The evidence was shared three days later, after the Home Ministry and senior IB officials intervened.

With the Centre turning its attention towards Maharashtra, Pandora's box of troubles may have just opened for the state police. Should this state of affairs continue and, god forbid, should Mumbai, yet again, become the target of a terror attack, the damage could be much worse.

with inputs from Aditi Pal

DGP A.N. ROY (BELOW) AND MUMBAI POLICE COMMISSIONER HASAN GAFOOR (BELOW LEFT)

MANDAR DEODHAR



Gafoor at first refused to share key evidence with the visiting FBI team. He was later forced to do so.